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Fill out this worksheet as a way to plan the data story you will make to examine your curiosity. Repeating this exercise as you work on your semester project will help ensure that you have a good data story.

1. Why did you pick your topic (i.e., problem)? That is, what made you curious about your topic (i.e., problem)?

We chose this topic because safety largely shapes how students experience campus, but those experiences are not always clearly understood or measured. From both personal observations and initial research, we noticed a potential gap between how students feel and what institutional data reports. This led us to explore whether student perceptions align with documented incidents and trends from official sources, such as crime logs and the Clery Report. Our goal is to combine these perspectives to identify meaningful gaps and provide actionable insights for improvement.

2. Plan and develop your data story (you will refine this as you continue your analysis, but this plan and the story you want to look for will help guide your analysis). To do so, let's first construct your outline (use the Knaflic Chapter 7 for additional guidance):

- *Your “beginning” (answer these below the question)*
 - What is the setting: When and where does the story take place?

The story takes place during Spring 2026 on and around the Virginia Tech campus in Blacksburg. It focuses on students' day-to-day experiences navigating campus, including classrooms, housing areas, transportation systems, and public spaces.

- Who is the main character: Who is driving the action?

The main characters are Virginia Tech students, especially those who experience safety concerns in their day-to-day lives on and around campus. Secondary characters include campus stakeholders who have the power to act on the findings: DABS, the Student Org Coalition, SSD, VT Facilities, Blacksburg Transit (BT), and VTPD.

- What is the imbalance: Why is it necessary, what has changed?

Stakeholders are not on campus every day and do not experience the day-to-day safety challenges that students encounter. Students have almost daily experiences with campus or BT transportation, during which they notice issues that don't work smoothly or safely. Identifying where stakeholder assumptions differ from student experiences can highlight specific areas for improvement and help Virginia Tech better support students.

- What is the balance: What do you want to see happen?

The goal is to create a clearer alignment between student perceptions and documented safety data. This involves identifying where perceptions and reported incidents overlap and where they diverge. It also requires understanding which groups are most affected and what factors contribute to those patterns. Achieving this balance will allow stakeholders to make more informed decisions.

- What is the solution: How will you bring about the change?

The solution is to integrate multiple data sources into a cohesive set of dashboards. By analyzing these datasets together, the project can highlight patterns in both perceived and documented safety issues. The dashboards will make it easier to identify key problem areas, affected groups, and gaps in awareness or confidence reporting. This approach gives stakeholders evidence they can use to prioritize interventions, assign ownership, and measure progress. In the final story, this means moving from broad campus safety messaging to targeted action around specific places, times, and trust gaps, especially nighttime safety, Pritchard Hall, transportation after dark, and communication about case outcomes.

- *Your “middle” (write down what you need to do for each bullet in the space provided below each bullet; you can use another sheet of paper if you need more space):*

- What relevant background will you need to cover in order to further develop the situation or problem(s).

It is important to provide context on how campus safety data is reported, including the role of VTPD Monthly Crime Logs. Background on transportation systems, like Blacksburg Transit, helps explain the barriers students reported. This allows the audience to interpret differences between reported data and lived experiences.

- What external context or comparison points do you need to incorporate?

We incorporate comparison points from the VTPD Crime Logs to validate survey trends against institutional metrics. In addition, the Virginia Tech 2024 Annual Security Report provides broader historical and policy context that helps explain whether short-term crime log patterns fit larger institutional trends.

- What examples can you give that illustrate the issue?

For example, we used our survey results to illustrate how safe students feel at specific times of day on campus, using a bar chart. Then, using the crime reports, we identified the locations and types of crimes in the area and visualized them as a map and a bar chart with count totals. This information allows us to compare student perceptions with documented crime counts and identify where concerns align with, or differ from, official incident patterns.

- What data will you need to include to demonstrate the problem(s)?

The analysis will combine survey data with institutional sources to provide a more complete picture of campus conditions. Survey data capture students' perceptions of safety, the frequency of transportation issues, and awareness of campus safety resources and reporting systems.

VTPD crime logs provide detailed information on incident types, locations, and timing, while the Clery Report offers broader trends over time. Together, these datasets allow for direct comparison between perceived experiences and documented incidents.

- What actions do you think will be required as a result of your analysis?

As of checkpoint 2, potential options include clearer communication on construction routes, and addressing late-night safety in high-incident areas like Pritchard or Slusher Hall. These actions should be translated into a small set of prioritized interventions, each with an assigned owner, such as VT Facilities, BT, DABS, Student Affairs, or VTPD.

- What do you think may be potential options for addressing the problem(s) and how can you illustrate these?

Potential options include improving lighting and visibility in high-concern areas, strengthening communication about reporting tools and available support services, and addressing recurring transportation concerns at bus stops and along late-night travel corridors. We can illustrate these options by pairing each recommendation with dashboard evidence showing the affected locations, student groups, time periods, and related incident patterns.

- What do you think the benefits of your recommended solution will be and how can you illustrate these?

Implementing these solutions can improve both actual safety conditions and students' perceptions of safety. By focusing on the most impactful issues, stakeholders can make more efficient and effective use of resources. This will help DABS, VT Facilities, BT, and student leaders focus resources on the locations, times, and student groups where improvements are most needed.

- How can you make it clear to your audience what they should know or do as a result of your findings?

The dashboards will present findings in a clear and structured way, making it easy to identify key patterns and priorities. Organizing insights by importance ensures that the most critical issues stand out. Connecting each finding to a specific recommendation makes the next steps clear for stakeholders.

- *Your “end” (write down what you think your ending will be in the space provided below the next bullet, you can use another sheet of paper if you need more space), that is write down what you think the “call to action” will be:*
 - End with a call to action: make it totally clear to your audience what you want them to do with the new understanding or knowledge that you’ve imparted to them.

Using our dashboards on safety, transportation, reporting confidence, case outcomes, and crime patterns, we will show where student perceptions align with official records and where important gaps remain. Based on these findings, DABS, VT Facilities, Blacksburg Transit, VTPD, and student leaders should move from general safety messaging to five targeted actions: launch a Pritchard Priority Plan, share case outcome updates with students quarterly, review Blacksburg Transit reliability and route coverage after 7 p.m., conduct a gender-informed nighttime walking audit, and add a short safety-and-reporting brief to fall orientation. Each action should have a clear owner, timeline, and success metric so stakeholders can track whether safety conditions and student confidence improve over time.

3. In the boxes below, storyboard your Tableau data story. In each box, write what that dashboard is going to be about and draw out the visual elements you will need to help tell that part of your data story. Remember, you should have a beginning, middle, and end. This is a “data story” so when you talk through this storyboard it should have a good flow.

Dashboard 01: Student Safety Perceptions across Different Demographics This dashboard opens the story by showing how safe students feel on and around Virginia Tech’s campus and whether that sense of safety changes across groups and times of day. It establishes the core tension in our project: safety is not experienced equally by all students. Our survey results suggest that perceptions of safety are lower after dark and lower among some demographic groups, especially women. The dashboard also introduces student confidence in reporting safety concerns, showing that trust in the reporting process is uneven across academic roles. This dashboard sets up the rest of the story by showing that student concerns are real, measurable, and not evenly distributed.	Dashboard 02: Resource Awareness & Reporting Confidence After understanding the differences in safety perceptions for different demographics, this dashboard asks whether students know about the resources designed to support them and whether they trust those systems to work. It focuses on awareness of tools such as VT Alerts, Safe Ride, and other university safety resources, and compares that awareness to students’ confidence that reported issues will actually be addressed. The key message is that having resources available is not the same as students trusting or using them. This dashboard deepens the story by showing that the issue is not only whether students feel safe, but also whether they feel supported by the systems meant to help them.	Dashboard 03: Transportation Safety & Student Perceptions After examining whether students know about and trust campus safety resources, this dashboard shifts to a more everyday, physical experience of safety: how students move around campus. It shows how safety perceptions differ across walking, biking, buses, and personal vehicles, and whether transportation-related issues affect students regularly. The takeaway is that safety concerns are not abstract; they are built into how students move through campus each day. This dashboard makes the problem more concrete by showing how safety concerns appear in routine student behavior and daily travel patterns, making the story more actionable for stakeholders such as Blacksburg Transit and campus planners.
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Dashboard 04: Geographic Distribution of Crimes Once student perceptions, daily experiences, and support systems have been established, this dashboard introduces institutional crime data to test whether those concerns align with documented incidents. The map highlights where crimes are concentrated across campus, while the offense breakdown shows which types of incidents occur most often. This is an important turning point in the story because it moves from what students believe and experience to what the official records show. By comparing perceived unsafe spaces with actual crime hotspots, this dashboard helps identify where concern and documented risk overlap most clearly.	Dashboard 05: Temporal Crime Patterns After showing where incidents occur, this dashboard shows when they occur. It examines crime patterns by time of day and over time, highlighting whether incidents are more concentrated during certain hours or periods. The main takeaway is that risk is not evenly distributed throughout the day, and nighttime emerges as an especially important period. This dashboard strengthens the earlier survey findings by showing whether the times students feel least safe match the times when incidents are most likely to happen. It adds another layer of evidence to the story and helps stakeholders think more precisely about timing-based interventions.	Dashboard 06: Case Outcomes & Resolution Patterns This dashboard adds another important layer by showing what happens after incidents are reported. It examines how cases are resolved, including whether they are referred to Student Conduct, cleared, or remain inactive, and whether resolution patterns differ by offense type. This matters because student trust in reporting is shaped not only by whether incidents occur, but also by whether students believe reports lead to meaningful action. By connecting offense types to case outcomes, this dashboard helps explain why some students may feel uncertain about the value of reporting concerns in the first place.
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Dashboard 07: Perceptions vs. Reality The final dashboard brings the story together by directly comparing student perceptions with documented crime patterns and reporting outcomes. It shows where student concerns align with institutional data and where gaps remain between what students feel and what official records capture. This concluding view helps decision-makers move from broad concern to targeted action. By the end of the story, the audience should understand which student groups feel least safe, where and when concerns are most concentrated, how those concerns compare with actual incidents, and which areas should be prioritized first. This dashboard supports the final call to action: stakeholders should use these findings to identify the highest-priority safety issues, assign ownership, and focus resources where they can make the most visible impact.		
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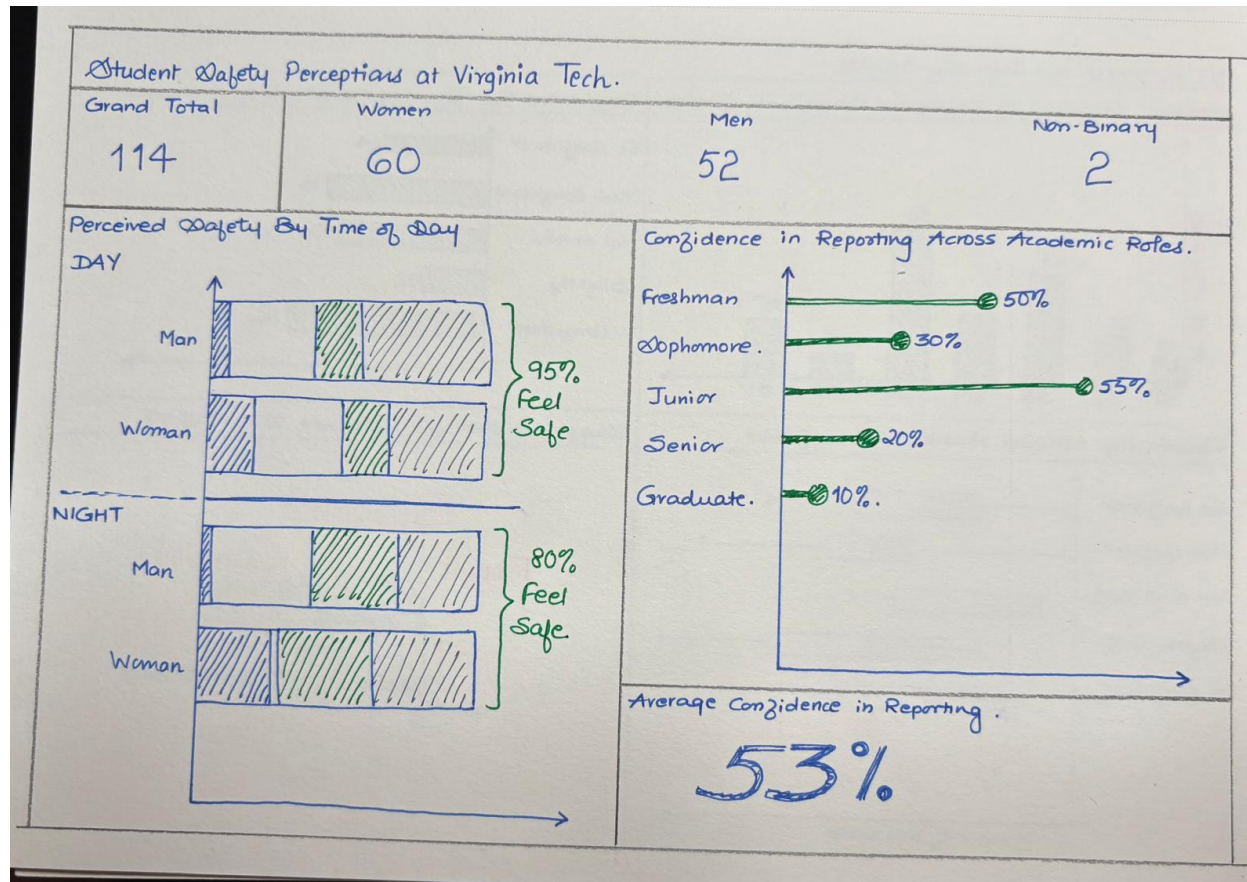


Figure 01: Rough Sketch for Dashboard 01

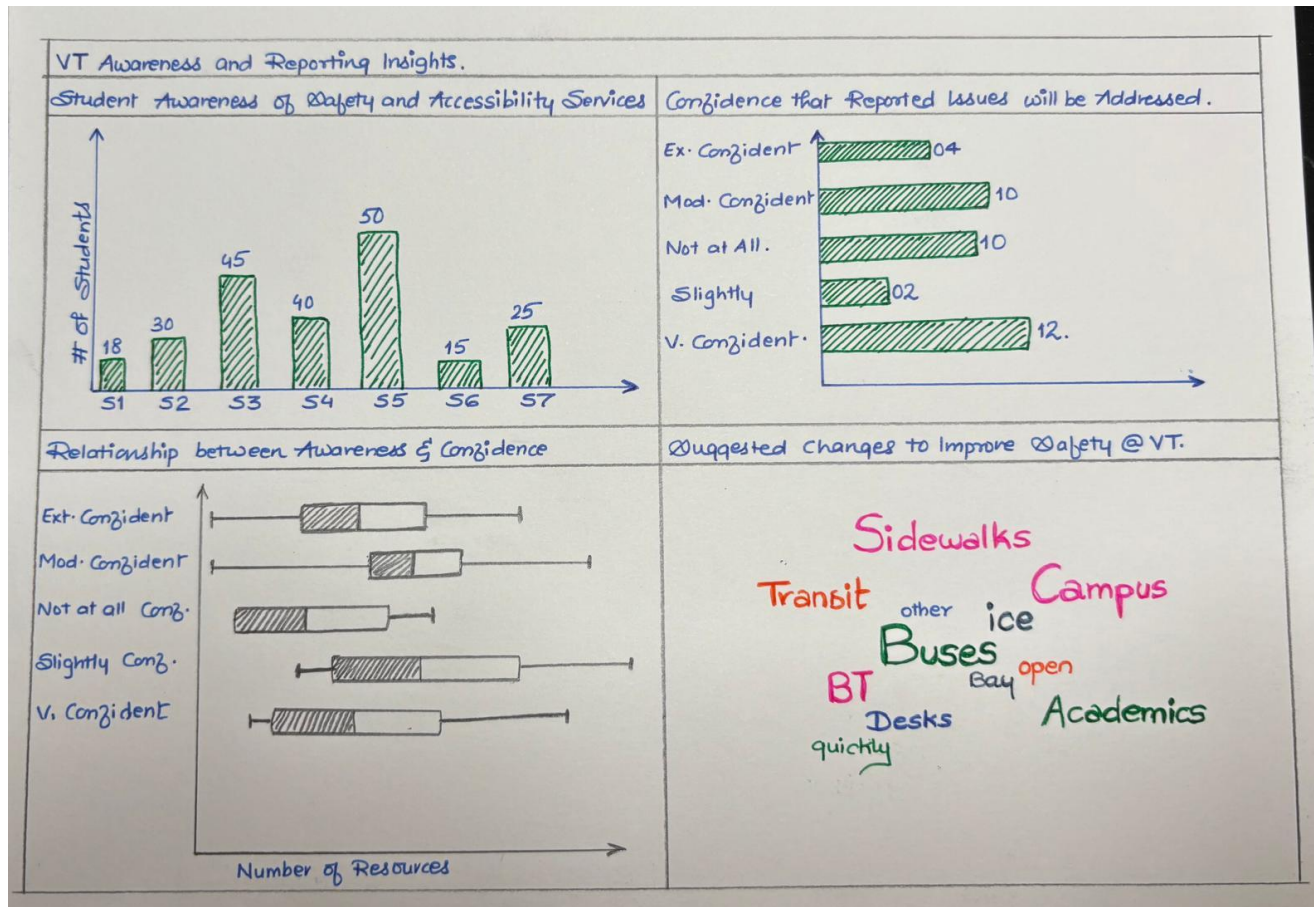


Figure 02: Rough Sketch for Dashboard 02

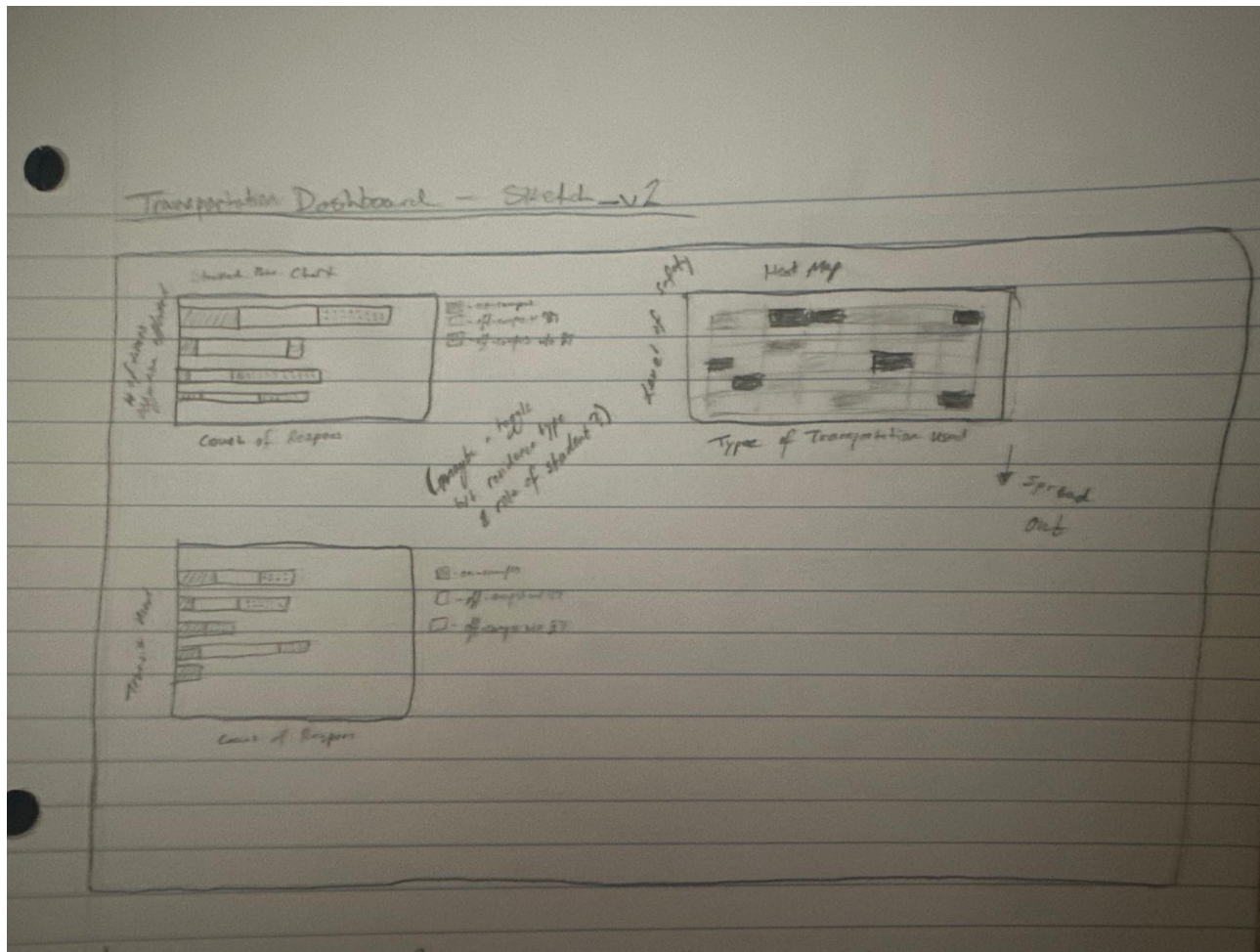


Figure 03: Rough Sketch for Dashboard 03

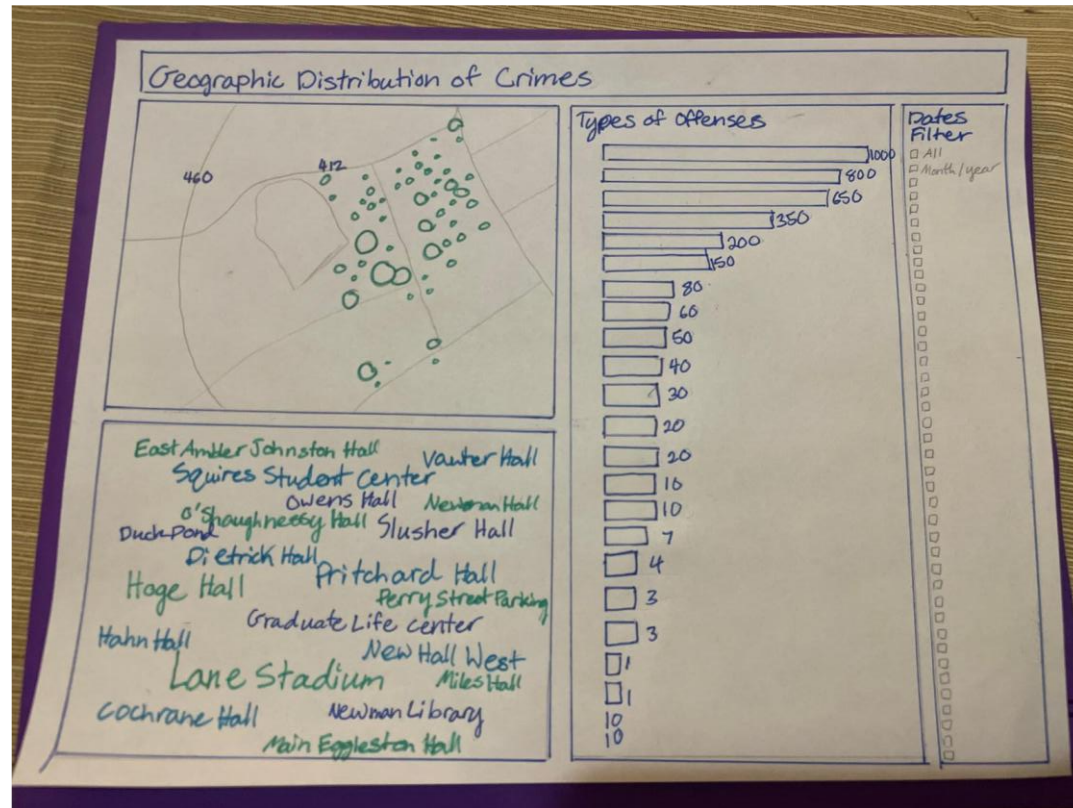


Figure 04: Rough Sketch for Dashboard 04

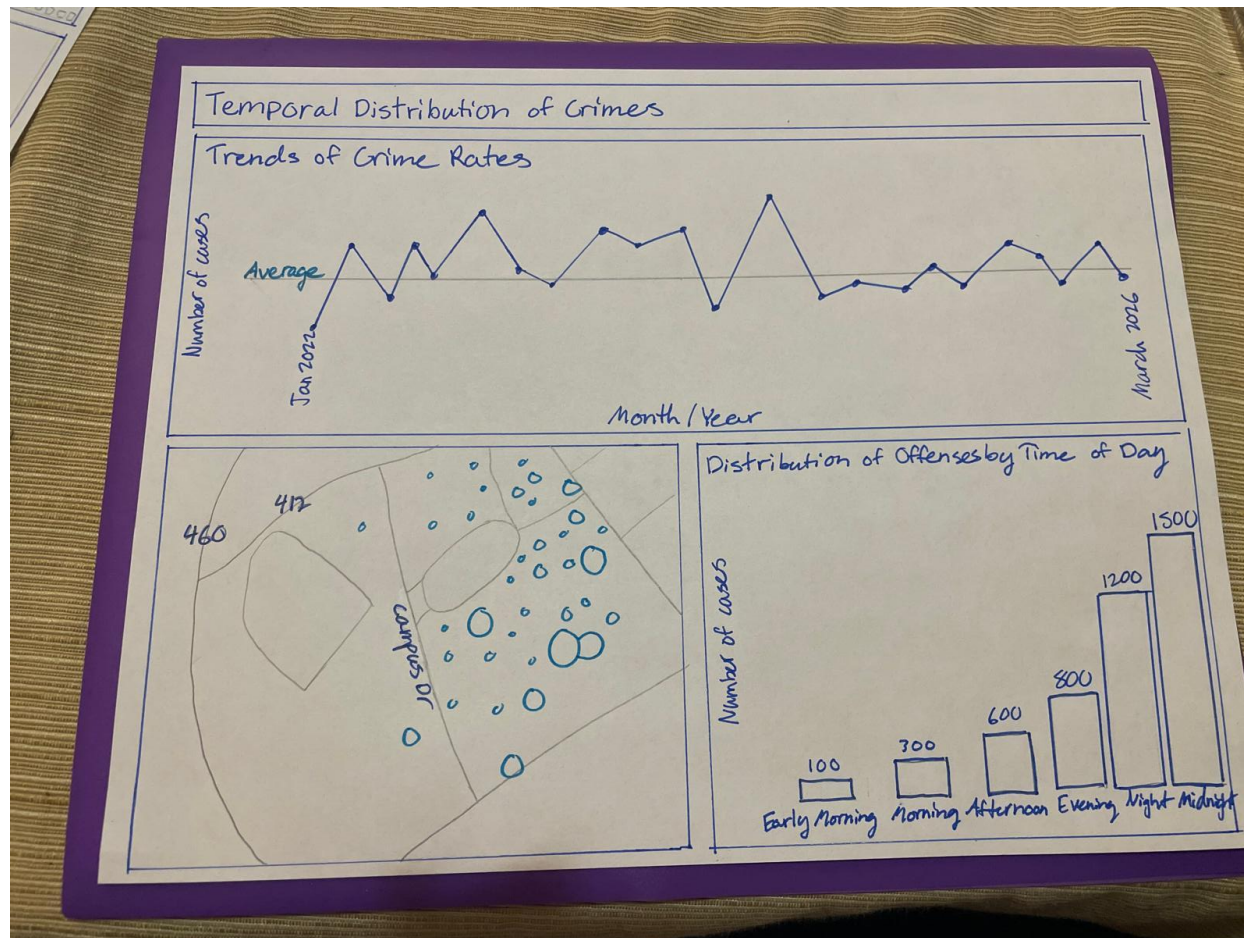


Figure 05: Rough Sketch for Dashboard 05

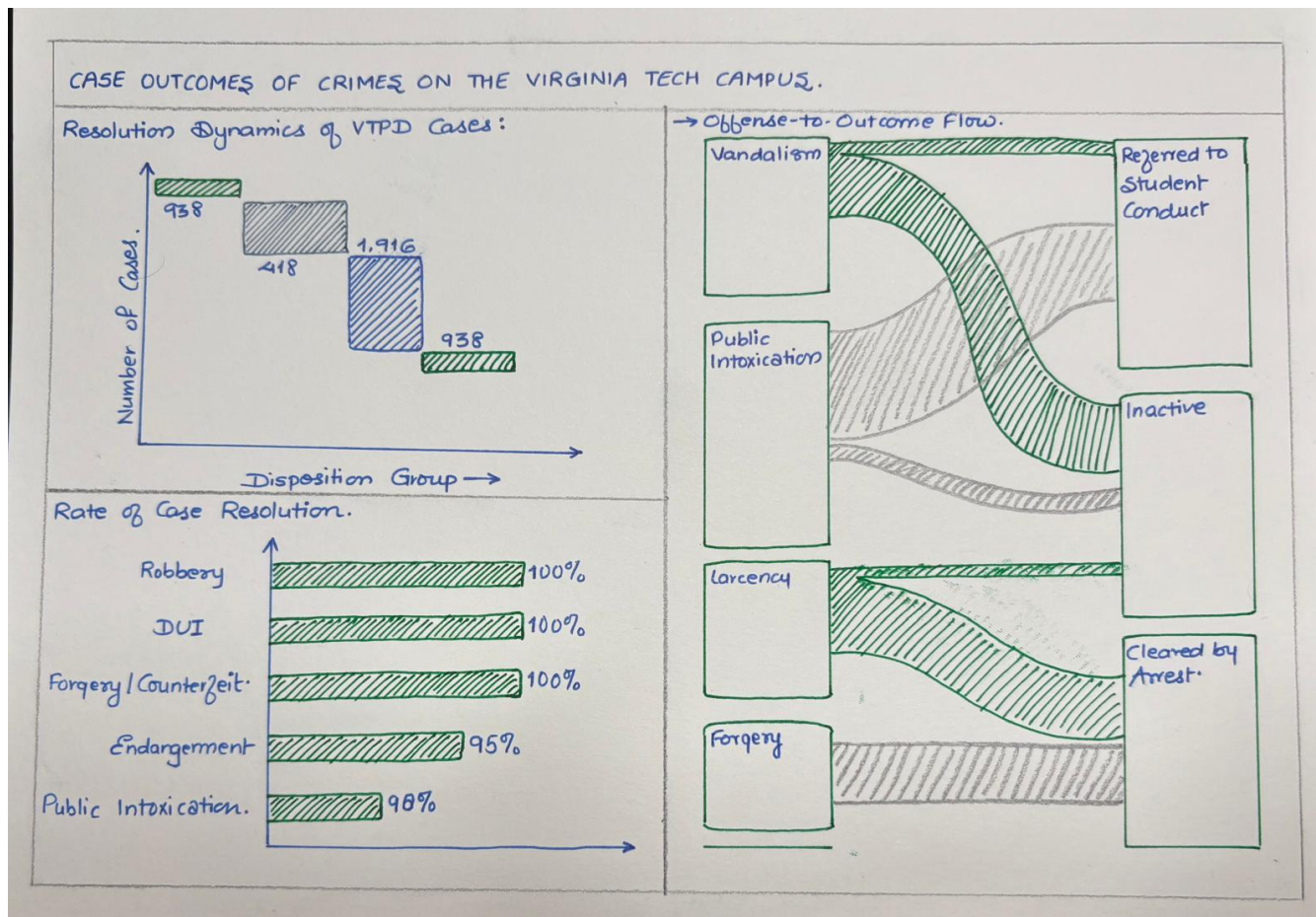


Figure 06: Rough Sketch for Dashboard 06

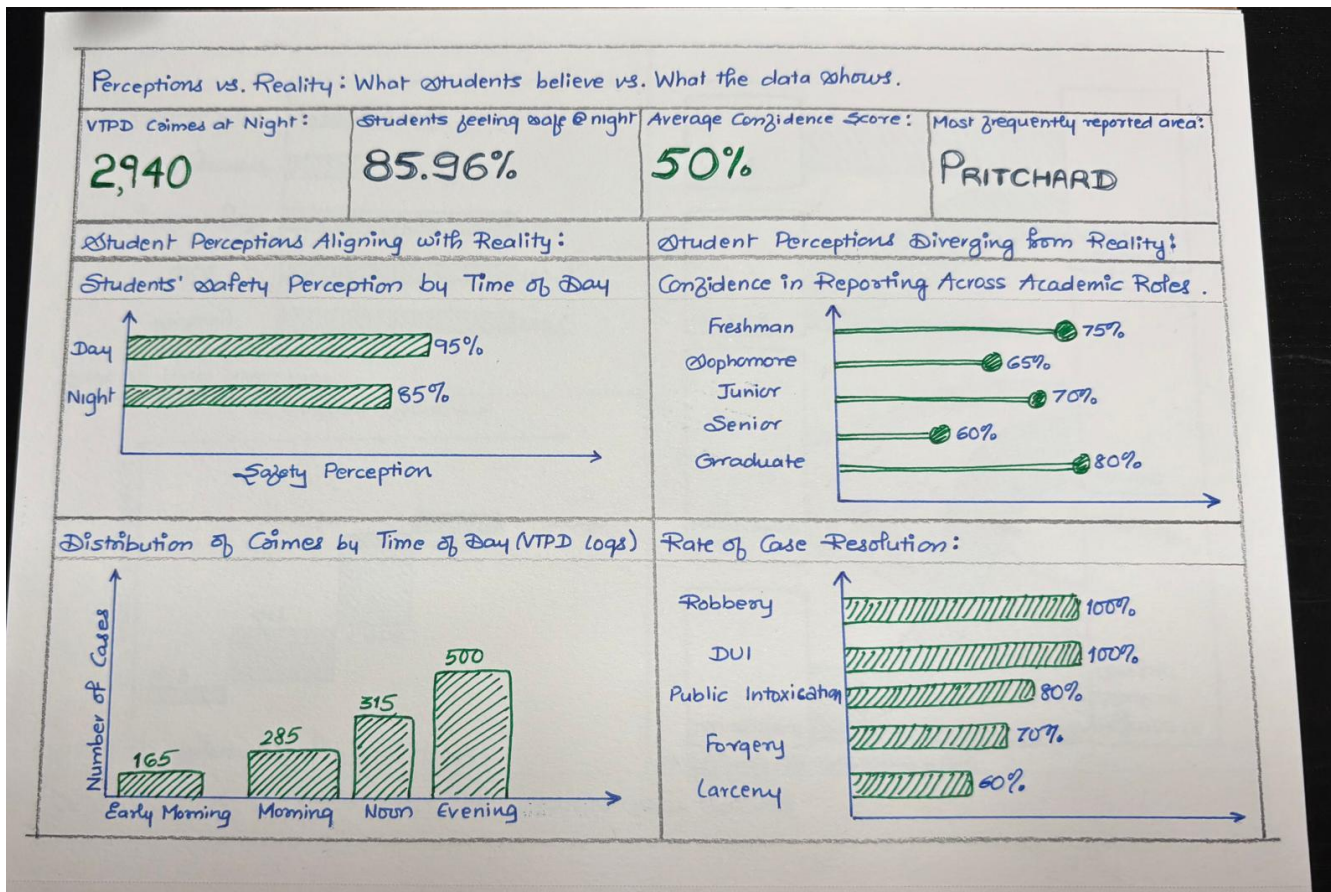


Figure 07: Rough Sketch for Dashboard 07

4. Write (in words) the story you want to tell for your project in the space that follows (write it like a real story):

At Virginia Tech, campus safety is not just a matter of policy or statistics. It is something students experience in small, repeated decisions every day: whether to walk alone after dark, whether to wait for the bus at night, whether to take a longer route that feels safer, or whether reporting a problem is even worth the effort. For many students, safety is shaped less by official messaging and more by what campus feels like in the moments that matter most.

That feeling, however, is not the same for everyone. Some students move through campus with more confidence than others, and that confidence often changes with time of day. What feels routine in the afternoon can feel uncertain at night. As a result, safety becomes more than an institutional issue; it becomes part of how students plan their schedules, navigate campus, and interpret the spaces around them.

Those everyday experiences become even more important when they begin to affect how students move through campus. Transportation is not separate from the story of safety; it is one of the clearest places where safety is lived. A late bus, a poorly lit stop, or a long walk through a quiet area can change how secure students feel and how willing they are to use certain routes or services. At the same time, the presence of campus safety resources does not automatically create trust. Students may know that tools and support systems exist, but that does not always mean they feel confident those systems will protect them or respond effectively when something goes wrong.

To understand whether these concerns reflect isolated perceptions or broader patterns, the story turns to institutional evidence. Crime records show where incidents are concentrated, when they happen most often, and which types of offenses appear most frequently across campus. In some places, the data confirms what students already feel: certain areas and certain times carry more visible risk. In other places, the gap between perception and documentation is just as meaningful, because persistent concern can still change behavior, shape routines, and weaken trust in the campus environment.

The story deepens further by asking what happens after an incident is reported. Students are more likely to trust the system when they believe reporting leads to action. Looking at case outcomes adds that missing layer. It shows whether reports are resolved, referred, or left inactive, and helps explain why confidence in reporting may be uneven. Safety is not only about where incidents occur, but also about whether students believe the institution responds in a meaningful and visible way.

In the end, this story is not simply about identifying where students feel unsafe. It is about showing campus leaders where concern, documented risk, and weak confidence intersect most clearly. That intersection is where action matters most. By using these findings to focus on high-concern locations, nighttime risk, transportation-related issues, and trust in reporting systems, campus stakeholders can move from broad concern to targeted improvement. The goal is a campus where students do not have to constantly adjust their behavior in response to uncertainty, but can instead move through their daily lives with greater confidence and security.

5. Now write down on this page all the questions you will need to ask of your data to confirm your story (or possibly find the real answers).

- Who responded to the survey, and how representative are they of key demographic groups and their exposure to campus?
- Do the places and times students feel least safe align with where and when incidents are documented in the VTPD crime logs?
- What safety concerns are reported most frequently, and in which specific campus locations are they concentrated?
- Does awareness of safety resources (like Safe Ride or VT Alerts) actually relate to a student's self-reported sense of safety?
- What are the most frequent incident types in the crime logs, and which ones align most closely with student-reported concerns?
- Which safety-related challenges and reporting concerns are most common, and how do they affect the student experience?
- Which specific issues should stakeholders prioritize first based on a combination of frequency and severity?
- What actionable takeaways and recommendations should be presented to owners like VT Facilities and VTPD to drive measurable change?